Assisting a Failed Train, Station Overruns, Stopping Short & Failing to Call

Train Driver Revision Guide | Module 4

Sources: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 (Jun 2026), GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 (Jun 2026), EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1

Part 1 — Assisting a Failed Train

Rule Book Module M2 (GERT8000-M2 Iss 9) covers the full procedure for trains stopped by failure and how assistance is arranged.

1.1 Stopped Out of Course / Unable to Make Progress

If your train is stopped out of course for any reason, or may be brought to a standstill, tell the signaller as soon as possible and state the cause. Reasons can include conductor rail icing, low adhesion, or insufficient traction power. In all cases, carry out the signaller's instructions.

Source: EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, Slide 5

1.2 When Your Train Fails — Telling the Signaller

If your train is stopped by failure, you must IMMEDIATELY tell the signaller about the circumstances and whether you need an assisting train. (M2 §1.1)

If you cannot speak to the signaller via GSM-R radio, you must use the quickest available means of doing so.

Other considerations after stopping:

- Get advice from Maintenance Control if needed
- Keep the guard informed, or make a PA announcement if Driver Only operation
- Update the signaller of any changes
- Inform the signaller if any line blocks are needed to examine the train

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §1.1; EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, Slide 8

1.3 Agreeing the Arrangements for Assistance

If an assisting train is needed, you and the signaller must both agree:

- the exact location of the failed train
- that the failed train will not be moved (declare the train a failure)
- the type of assisting train needed, and
- the direction from which it is needed

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §1.2

1.4 Making the Failed Train Safe

After asking for assistance, you must not move your failed train until the assisting train arrives OR you have agreed alternative arrangements with the signaller and anyone else concerned.

Ensure the correct lights are displayed:

- If assistance is coming from the REAR — display a RED light at the rear of your train
- If assistance is coming from the FRONT — display a WHITE light at the front of your train

On a single line: if you hold the token, you must keep it until the assisting train arrives.

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §1.3

1.5 Telling the Guard

If you leave the failed train to speak to the signaller, you must tell the guard (if provided):

- that you are leaving the train
- the direction from which assistance will be provided, if known

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §1.4

1.6 Working Outside the Train on a Running Line

If you need to work on the outside of a train stopped on a running line due to failure or other exceptional incident, and DANGER would arise if trains continue to pass on the adjoining line(s):

- Before starting work, ask the signaller to STOP the passage of trains on those lines
- Obtain an assurance that this has been done and receive an authority number
- It may be necessary to wait for the passage of trains to be stopped

1E13 Incident (3 Aug 2016): A driver had to lie down next to their train to avoid a passing train at 105 mph. This was because the driver FAILED to reach a clear understanding with the signaller. Always confirm what lines are stopped before working outside.

Source: EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, Slides 6-7; GERT8000-TW1 §49

1.7 Waiting for the Assisting Train to Arrive — Driver of Failed Train

Normal Arrangement

When the signaller tells you the assisting train is ready to enter the section:

- Ask the signaller to put you in contact with the driver of the assisting train by GSM-R
- (Not required if the failed train will be clearly visible from where the assisting train is standing)
- Speak to the assisting driver via GSM-R to give the exact location of the failed train

If you cannot speak to the assisting driver via GSM-R, you must:

- Remain on the train
- Pass information (including exact location) to the signaller for relay
- Wait for the assisting train to arrive

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.1a

Poor Visibility — No GSM-R Contact with Assisting Driver

During poor visibility, if you cannot speak to the assisting driver via GSM-R, go to one of the following:

- A point 300 metres (approx 300 yards) from your train in the direction the assisting train will approach
- A stop signal or block marker less than 300 metres from your train — provided the signaller confirms it is protecting your train
- A tunnel entrance less than 300 metres from your train

- If your train has failed inside a tunnel and 300m falls within the tunnel — continue through the tunnel to the far end

You must:

- Stay at that point and wait for the assisting train
- Display a hand danger signal as the assisting train approaches

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.1b

1.8 Driver of the Assisting Train

Movement Towards the Failed Train

- Proceed at CAUTION — maximum 25 mph (40 km/h)
- Use GSM-R to speak to the driver of the failed train to get/give necessary information before the movement
- You do not need to speak continuously during the movement
- If no GSM-R contact with failed train driver, follow the signaller's instructions — the signaller will relay any information including exact location

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.3

If You Need to Pick Up the Driver of the Failed Train

- Keep a look out for, and stop to pick up, the driver of the failed train
- Only enter a tunnel if you have already picked up the failed train driver, OR you know the driver is NOT in the tunnel and the tunnel is clear
- If the failed train driver is not at the expected point — stay and wait for them to arrive
- After picking up the failed train driver, they must confirm the exact location of the failed train before you proceed

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.3

Driver of the Failed Train — Conducting the Assisting Train (Poor Visibility)

If during poor visibility the signaller could not put you in contact with the assisting driver, and you are waiting at the required point:

- When the assisting train arrives, get in the driving cab of the assisting train
- Confirm the exact location of the failed train to that driver

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.4

1.9 Coupling to the Failed Train

If you are the driver of the assisting train, before moving the coupled trains, you must ensure:

- Your train is coupled to the failed train
- The automatic brake (if compatible) is connected

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.5

1.10 When the Failed Train is Being Assisted

If you are the driver of the assisting train at the REAR of the failed train:

- Temporarily isolate the TPWS before the movement starts
- Reinstate the TPWS when the movement is finished

You can use train radio to speak to the other driver at any time to start, stop and control the movement.

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.6

1.11 Both Drivers — During the Assisted Movement

- The driver at the LEADING END keeps the token (single line) until both trains are clear of the section
- Establish which train is going forward (i.e. the stopping pattern)
- Get permission to move from the signaller
- Use GSM-R if needed to start, stop and control the move
- When the movement is complete, speak with the signaller before any further movement

Source: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 §3.7; EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, Slide 19

1.12 Assisting Train Running in the Wrong Direction

Single Line Working does not apply in this situation. Instead:

- You will be given clear instructions about what is required and how far to proceed
- If the wrong-direction movement over an adjacent line is more than 400 yards, ensure a WHITE light is displayed at the front and a RED light at the rear

Always make sure you clearly understand what is required and how far you can proceed before making any wrong-direction assisting movement.

Source: EMR PPT M2 Assistance v9, Slide 20

Part 2 — Station Overruns

Source: GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 §39; EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1

2.1 Definition

A station overrun is an incident where the front of the train passes the end of the platform by at least the position of the first passenger door. In extreme cases, the whole train may have passed through the station.

> **Some stations may have a stop car marker board beyond the platform end for loco-hauled stock.**

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 3

2.2 Immediate Actions After an Overrun

If you have a guard who is responsible for releasing the doors:

- Immediately tell the guard/conductor using bell or buzzer code 2-2

If on a Driver Only train:

- Make a PA announcement IMMEDIATELY — tell passengers NOT to get out of the train

If the doors have already been released by mistake:

- Check that no one has fallen from the train before moving
- Tell the signaller if someone has fallen, or if you cannot be certain whether anyone has fallen
- Ensure any passenger who got off is not in danger before making any further movement

Source: GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 §39.1; EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slides 5-6

2.3 Returning to the Platform After an Overrun

You may return to the platform only if BOTH of the following apply:

- The overrun is no more than 400 metres (440 yards) beyond the platform
- You have received permission from the signaller

When permission has been granted:

- Tell the guard permission has been given to return
- Make good use of the PA to keep passengers informed (guard, or driver if DO)
- Always change ends and drive back into the station — NEVER set back
- If the train has to pass over a level crossing, make sure the crossing is clear first

Source: GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 §39.2; EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slides 7-8

2.4 Unable to Return to the Platform

You are NOT allowed to return to the platform if ANY of the following apply:

- The overrun is more than 400 metres beyond the platform
- The signaller does not give permission

In this case:

- Tell the guard (if provided) and make a PA announcement
- When all doors are closed and can no longer be released, arrange with the person in charge of the platform for the train to be moved so that passengers who want to get off can do so safely

Source: GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 §39.2; EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 9

Part 3 — Stopping Short

3.1 Definition

A stop short incident is where the train has come to a stand with at least one of its doors overhanging the beginning of the platform edge — i.e. the train has not reached the correct stopping position.

You should identify this from your train not reaching the correct car stop marker, or visually if the train is clearly short of the platform edge.

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 10

3.2 Actions When Stopped Short

The actions are the same as for an overrun:

- Immediately tell the guard using bell or buzzer code 2-2 (if guard is responsible for doors)
- If on a DO train, make a PA announcement telling passengers not to get out
- If doors have been released by mistake, check no one has fallen from the train
- Tell the signaller if someone has fallen or you cannot be certain

Before making any movement to correct the stop position, ensure all doors are closed and can no longer be released.

You must get the signaller's permission before making any of the following:

- A wrong-direction movement
- A movement towards a signal at danger
- Any movement on a permissive platform line

Source: GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 §39.1

Part 4 — Failing to Call at a Station

4.1 Definition

A failure to call is when a train fails to stop at a station it was planned to call at.

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 11

4.2 Common Causes

- Over-speed on approach
- Lack of route knowledge
- Not consulting the working diagram or liaising with the guard about scheduled stops
- Low adhesion
- Poor visibility
- Poor judgement of distance, gradient and approach speed
- Signal clearing on approach to a platform with a red at the end — causing the driver to continue without stopping

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 11

4.3 Immediate Actions

Inform:

- The signaller
- The guard/conductor
- Passengers (via PA)

Arrangements must then be made with operations control to stop the train at the next suitable station so that over-carried passengers can be dealt with.

The train may be stopped out of course due to activation of the passenger communication apparatus following a fail to call.

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slide 12

4.4 Strategies for Avoidance

- Know the hot-spots for fail to call incidents on your route and the reasons why drivers have previously made errors there
- Never assume — always verify the train stopping points and check for any amendments to the stopping pattern
- Highlight any unusual station stops
- Do not rely solely on experience for stopping patterns
- Check the stops for each journey before departing the previous station, and again prior to the braking point for the next station
- Cross off stops on the diagram when safe to do so

Red 40 — Signal, Speed, Station concept:

This "short journey" concept helps prevent fail to calls, SPADs and speeding by focusing on three key elements as you approach any station: the Signal ahead, your Speed, and the Station. It is an NTS (Non-Technical Skills) tool.

Other approaches include commentary driving and risk-based commentary driving.

Source: EMR PPT 33-03 v4.1, Slides 13-14

Q&A — Self-Test Questions

All answers are rule-book sourced.

Assisting a Failed Train

Question	Answer
What must you do IMMEDIATELY if your train is stopped by failure?	Tell the signaller about the circumstances and whether you need an assisting train. (M2 §1.1)
What four things must you and the signaller agree before an assisting train is sent?	1) Exact location of failed train. 2) That the failed train will not be moved. 3) Type of assisting train needed. 4) Direction from which it is needed. (M2 §1.2)
Which light must you display at the rear if assistance is coming from behind?	A red light. (M2 §1.3)
Which light must you display at the front if assistance is coming from the front?	A white light. (M2 §1.3)
On a single line, what must you do with the token?	Keep it until the assisting train arrives. (M2 §1.3)
During poor visibility, if you cannot speak to the assisting driver via GSM-R, how far must you go towards the assisting train?	300 metres (approximately 300 yards) from your train in the direction the assisting train will approach. (M2 §3.1b)
What must you display when the assisting train approaches in poor visibility?	A hand danger signal. (M2 §3.1b)
What is the maximum speed for the assisting train moving towards the failed train?	25 mph (40 km/h). (M2 §3.3)
When must the assisting train driver only enter a tunnel?	When they have already picked up the failed train driver, OR they know the failed train driver is not in the tunnel and the tunnel is clear. (M2 §3.3)
What must the assisting train driver do regarding TPWS when assisting from the rear?	Temporarily isolate TPWS before the movement starts, and reinstate it when the movement is finished. (M2 §3.6)
Who keeps the token on a single line during the assisting movement?	The driver at the leading end of the movement. (M2 §3.7)
If working outside the train on a running line, what must you obtain from the signaller?	An assurance that trains have been stopped on those lines, and an authority number. (TW1 §49)
If an assisting train runs in the wrong direction for more than 400 yards, what lights are required?	White light at the front, red light at the rear. (EMR PPT M2 Slide 20)

Station Overruns

Question	Answer
How is a station overrun defined?	The front of the train passes the end of the platform

	by at least the position of the first passenger door. (TW1 §39 / PPT)
What is the bell/buzzer code to alert the guard immediately?	Code 2-2. (PPT 33-03)
If doors have been released by mistake after an overrun, what must you do first?	Check that no one has fallen from the train before moving. (TW1 §39.1)
When CAN you return to the platform after an overrun?	Only if the overrun is no more than 400 metres (440 yards) AND you have the signaller's permission. (TW1 §39.2)
When CANNOT you return to the platform after an overrun?	If the overrun is more than 400 metres, or the signaller does not give permission. (TW1 §39.2)
Must you change ends to return to the platform after an overrun?	Yes — always change ends and drive back. Never set back. (PPT 33-03)
If the train must pass a level crossing to return to the platform, what must you check?	That the crossing is clear. (TW1 §39.2)

Stopping Short

Question	Answer
How is a stop short defined?	The train comes to a stand with at least one of its doors overhanging the beginning of the platform edge. (PPT 33-03)
Before correcting a stop short by drawing forward, what must be done with the doors?	All doors must be closed and can no longer be released. (TW1 §39.1)
What types of movement after a stop short require the signaller's permission?	A wrong-direction movement, a movement towards a signal at danger, or any movement on a permissive platform line. (TW1 §39.1)

Failing to Call

Question	Answer
What is a "failure to call"?	When a train fails to stop at a station it was planned to call at. (PPT 33-03)
Name three common causes of a fail to call.	Over-speed, lack of route knowledge, low adhesion, poor visibility, signal clearing on approach (any three). (PPT 33-03)
Who must you inform after a fail to call?	The signaller, the guard/conductor, and passengers (via PA). (PPT 33-03)
What is the "Red 40" or Signal-Speed-Station concept?	A short journey tool to prevent fail to calls, SPADs and speeding — focus on the Signal ahead, your Speed, and the Station as you approach each stop. (PPT 33-03)
If a passenger operates the communication apparatus after a fail to call, what may happen?	The train may be stopped out of course. (PPT 33-03)

Sources: GERT8000-M2 Iss 9 (Jun 2026) | GERT8000-TW1 Iss 22 (Jun 2026) | EMR PPT M2 Assistance June 2026 v9 | EMR PPT 33-03 Station Overruns v4.1